We can see certain trends from this figure that can be explained by domestic as well international factors. In the first years of transnationalisation, the process was in its infant stage and only a few transnational contracts were signed each year. Thus Brazilian firms made their first investments in foreign markets in that moment and the number of contracts agreed annually was, in general, low. This characterised the first seven years of the period between 1969 and 1975, which also represents the peak of domestic demand for public works within Brazil; even so, Brazilian contractors sought opportunities abroad. In order to understand the beginnings of the construction industry's transnationalisation process, it is important to highlight the Asian and African independence movements on the international scene as well as the lines of credit of the World Bank and Inter-American Development Bank accompanying international tenders for Latin American public works. Driven by these two factors, the Brazilian companies obtained their first overseas contracts.

Nonetheless, with the worldwide petroleum shock of 1973 and the redirection of domestic policies toward incentivising the export of manufactured goods and services mainly through the creation of political-economy mechanisms favouring civil engineering firms acting abroad after 1975, what one notes is that the transnationalisation process gained more vigour from 1976 and was prolonged until 1983. Despite this being a period of stagnation and even retraction of domestic demand for public works, the companies that established overseas contracts were precisely the country's largest, which maintained a moderate level of domestic activity, as they were anchored in the dictatorship's huge ongoing projects, such as the Itaipu and Tucuruí hydroelectric projects, the Angra nuclear power stations and the Carajás project.

Between 1984 and 1987 business activity abroad stagnated.[5] This reality can be explained both by the international recession and the inertia of the Brazilian economy in the face of public works sector failures as well as by diminished state support for these companies' foreign investments. The 1980s were characterised by a global and Latin American recession along with a consequent weakness of demand for public works in those markets where Brazilian contractors had their principal activity.

After this downturn in civil engineering services exports, 1988 saw the beginning of an extremely vigorous period of Brazilian contractors' international expansion; now led by Andrade Gutierrez and Odebrecht – and no longer by Mendes Júnior – they even acquired foreign construction companies and established themselves in such promising markets as Portugal and the United States. Between 1988 and the mid-1990s there was a period in which more than ten